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**Basic Requirements for the Master of Finance (MF)
Degree Thesis and Practical Achievement Submitted for
Degree Application at the Shanghai Advanced Institute
of Finance, Shanghai Jiao Tong University**

**Master of Finance Program
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Introduction

Successful completion of a degree thesis defense or the prescribed practical achievement defense is a prerequisite for the conferment of the Master of Finance (MF) professional degree. The completion of a degree thesis or the attainment of a practical achievement constitutes an essential component of Master of Finance education and serves as comprehensive training for students' ability to independently undertake professional financial practice.

The Master of Finance (MF) Program Office of Shanghai Advanced Institute of Finance (hereinafter referred to as "SAIF") has formulated these requirements in accordance with relevant regulations and guidelines issued by the Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China and the National Steering Committee for Graduate Education in Finance. These requirements apply to all stages of degree thesis and practical achievement work undertaken by MF students, including topic selection, writing, mid-term review, and defense. They serve as a guiding document for the administration and evaluation of degree theses and practical achievements by the School's administrative departments, the Professional Degree Thesis Supervision Committee (hereinafter referred to as the "TSC"), the Academic Degree Committee (hereinafter referred to as the "ADC"), and academic supervisors.

These requirements will be continuously updated in accordance with relevant regulations and policy documents issued by the Ministry of Education, the Shanghai Municipal Education Commission, the National Steering Committee for Graduate Education in Finance, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, and Shanghai Advanced Institute of Finance.

For further information, please contact the MF Program Office at: mf.operations@saif.sjtu.edu.cn.



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Chapter 1: Advisor

The advisor must be a member of the SAIF qualified faculty approved by the Thesis Supervision Committee (TSC). Students should be passionate about their chosen research field, take the initiative in conducting research, play a leading role in the writing of their thesis or practical achievement, and take full responsibility for their work. The advisor provides professional guidance and ensures the quality of the student's thesis or practical achievement. During the writing of the thesis or practical achievement, students may communicate with their advisors via in-person meetings, telephone, email, or WeChat. The advisor can not be changed without special reasons.

1.1 Advisor Responsibilities and Requirements

In accordance with the relevant regulations on advisor management at SAIF, advisor should have:

- 1) A doctoral degree in a related field;
- 2) Relevant knowledge, expertise and interest in the participant's research topic;
- 3) Sufficient time to guide the thesis or practical achievement and strictly fulfill the supervisory responsibilities.
- 4) The means to provide guidance until the student passes the final defense, should a student apply for suspension, extension or fails in the evaluation stage.

1.2 Duties

Advisors are expected to assist students in all stages of writing the thesis or practical achievement, including but not limited to:

- 1) Guiding students in selecting research topics that meet the following requirements: a) The topic must be feasible within a reasonable timeframe; b) The topic should focus on financial practice, applications, or practical financial needs; c) The scope and depth of the research must demonstrate the student's comprehensive ability to analyze and solve practical problems using financial theory, knowledge, and skills; d) The topic must be innovative and allow for the further expansion of the student's foundational knowledge;



- 2) Assisting students in developing research plans, including establishing and monitoring progress schedules;
- 3) Providing students with the necessary knowledge and resources to implement their research plans;
- 4) Urging students to follow the Academic Integrity Code. The final drafts of theses or practical achievements submitted by students will undergo originality checks by the MF program team using the university's designated plagiarism detection system. For relevant provisions regarding determination and handling, please refer to the SAIF Academic Integrity Code.
- 5) Ensure students strictly adhere to their established writing plans and the School's relevant procedural arrangements; regularly monitor students' writing progress; advisors may choose to provide guidance via face-to-face meetings, telephone calls, or online conferences on a weekly or biweekly basis;
- 6) Evaluate students' theses or practical achievements during the proposal, first draft, and final stages via written feedback (if necessary) or through an online system; Advisors have the authority to review students' theses or reports at all stages of the thesis/practical achievement process. If a student's thesis or practical achievement report does not meet the relevant requirements, the advisor has the right to return it to the student for further revision, and the student must resubmit it only after completing the required revisions.
- 7) Providing guidance in proposal defense and final defense.



Chapter 2: Degree Thesis Requirements

2.1 Basic Requirements

The degree thesis can be written in Chinese or English. If the research field pertains to Chinese corporations or the Chinese capital market, students may have the thesis written in Chinese. Theses written in English will be evaluated based on the 'Administrative Measures for the International Review and Defense of Dissertations' announced by the school.

Thesis topics mainly include case study, financial product development, strategy research, research report, thematic research, and empirical research. Theses written in Chinese must be no less than 20,000 words, while those written in English must be no less than 15,000 words.

2.1.1 Case Study

A case study is a form of thesis writing in which students apply their knowledge of economic and financial theories to analyze and solve problems related to a specific enterprise or event. Theses in this category involve conducting objective and in-depth investigations into practical financial issues. Based on the detailed data and information gathered, students conduct systematic research using relevant financial theories and visualization tools to analyze the decision-making processes, intrinsic value, and risk profiles of the subject under study.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements

The topic should be representative and novel, with a focused research question and a certain level of theoretical depth. Research questions should be formulated by integrating financial practice with the theoretical knowledge acquired. The thesis should present case materials that are as rich and detailed as possible.

The topic should be derived from real-world micro-level entities or events in the field of economic and financial practice that reflect relevant theories. Case studies generally utilize first-hand case information with both theoretical and practical value, or publicly disclosed information. The case information for the topic should particularly emphasize characteristics such as professionalism, typicality, distinctiveness, and theoretical insight, while also possessing practical value and feasibility.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements



The case study should systematically collect, organize, and process comprehensive information regarding the case enterprise or event, presenting the case information in a structured and readable format. Specialized knowledge, professional theories, and methods should be employed to systematically analyze the information and propose policy recommendations. Specific approaches and methods for solving the problem should be presented.

The analytical methods and process must be scientific, rigorous, and internally consistent.

3. Thesis structure

The thesis should demonstrate a substantial workload and conform to academic writing standards. The main body of the thesis generally includes the following sections:

(1) Introduction

Present the situation and background of the case study, as well as the problems faced by the enterprise. In this section, students will explain the questions to be studied in this case, including general questions and specific questions.

(2) Theoretical framework and literature review

Propose the research point and innovative and contributive points of the thesis with full discussion and summary of the relevant literatures across the world. More than 20 literatures should be cited, and the cited literatures should not be too old. Students should provide general solutions of general questions from the introduction.

(3) Case background and data

Describe the background of the case company and its industry in detail to demonstrate the information collected. Based on the practical issue, the data and literature collected should be reviewed to clarify the causes and trends of the issue and provide evidence for scheme design. A majority of the data used in the thesis should come from in-depth investigations and direct observations of relevant enterprises, sectors, and financial markets. Through the author's in-depth analysis and processing, the data shall be presented, summarized, and concluded in an intuitive and objective manner.

(4) Case analysis

This section should contain core research of the thesis. Students should put forward specific solutions to answer the specific questions from the introduction.



Explain the idea, conditions and details of scheme design, characteristics and innovation of the scheme, key points of implementation, and the potential risks to convey the practical value of the thesis. If necessary, compare with relevant research reports, summarize and evaluate existing findings and conclusions, and provide evidence for research design.

(5) Conclusion

Based on the findings, a clear conclusion shall be formed, and decisions and solutions proposed, which echo the purpose of the analysis mentioned in the introduction.

(6) Appendix

This section should include main data supporting the conclusion of the thesis, including questionnaires, interview records, copy of files, raw data reports, program codes, etc., which indicate the surveyed organizations and individuals or the data source to provide sufficient credibility.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

The case study should demonstrate innovative application of theory by applying financial theory to new case studies, proposing innovative solutions, and offering new approaches to practical problems or providing new perspectives and interpretations. The case study should demonstrate the author's ability to utilize data analysis methods or tools to enhance the depth and breadth of the analysis. The results of the case study should provide practical guidance for the financial sector.

2.1.2 Financial Product Development

Financial product development describes the introduction of a new financial product, including hedge fund strategies, and provides discussion of its pricing, profitability, attractiveness, and execution. The scheme design of financial innovative products is an innovative or creative contract arrangement or solution to financial practical problems, which has the characteristics of customization and non-standardization. The thesis not only analyzes a new financial product or financial transaction mechanism designed independently, but also analyzes the existing new financial product or financial transaction mechanism. Typical financial innovation products include structured financial products launched by commercial Banks.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements



The research subjects must be financial products or trading systems. The design of the financial products or trading systems shall focus on solving real-world financial problems and have clear practical applications.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements

Study the functionality, yield, and risk characteristics of new financial products or trading systems and their potential applications.

Comprehensively use the fundamental theories and techniques of finance, accounting, and economics as well as quantitative analytical tools of financial engineering, mathematical finance, and financial simulation, while taking account of tax and legal constraints.

3. Thesis structure

The thesis should demonstrate a substantial workload and conform to academic writing standards. The main body of the thesis generally includes the following sections:

(1) Introduction

Describe the context of new financial products and trading systems, analyze user needs, and clarify the financial problems to be solved by the products or trading systems.

(2) Theoretical framework and literature review

Review the literature and findings of the products and trading systems to further demonstrate their practical significance. Generally, more than 20 literatures should be cited, and the cited literatures should not be too old.

(3) Product design

This section shall reflect the idea, conditions or feasibility of the solution design, the content and key points of implementation, characteristics, and possible problems.

Specifically, it is necessary to analyze in detail the specific requirements of users in terms of yield, risk, and cash flow targetted at the financial problems to be solved. Design or analyze the financial products or solutions that meet the requirements, using new financial instruments or improvements, splits and combinations of existing financial instruments, including contractual terms (rights and obligations) and trading approaches (including clearing and delivery arrangements, exit or termination conditions).

(4) Pricing analysis



Based on the above product design, comprehensive quantitative analysis methods such as mathematical finance, numerical calculation and financial simulation shall be used to analyze the quantitative relationship between product value, risks, cash flow, and other measures and key parameters. In addition, it is essential to explore the effects of transaction costs, taxes, etc. on the above measures and demonstrate whether the product design meets the specific needs of or solves the corresponding financial problems. If necessary, the product design shall be modified and improved based on the pricing analysis.

(5) Marketing analysis

Analyze the potential customers (distribution targets) and market potential of the products and compare them with similar products.

(6) Conclusion

Based on the above design and analysis results, describe the overall evaluation and conclusion of the product corresponding to the financial problems to be analyzed and solved in the introduction.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

Financial product development primarily focuses on novel financial products, covering analyses of strategy, pricing, returns, markets, and sales. Innovative financial products emphasize solving real-world financial problems through innovative contracts or solutions, often taking the form of customized, non-standardized products. These may independently design entirely new financial products and trading mechanisms, or conduct research and analysis on existing novel financial product categories.

2.1.3 Strategy Research

Strategy research is the process of conducting in-depth analysis and evaluation of various financial strategies, aiming to provide guidance to financial market participants on how to make rational decisions under different market conditions, as expressed through a thesis.

Strategy research includes, but is not limited to, providing technical support to investors through quantitative investment models, risk hedging strategies, and asset allocation optimization to help enhance investment returns and mitigate risks; assisting enterprises in optimizing financing plans, capital structures, or M&A strategies, or maximizing profits through financial instruments; and providing government agencies and other entities with economic trend analysis, financial risk assessments, and policy impact studies to inform decision-



making. Competitive strategy research must meet the following requirements: the demands of social development, the need for risk-return alignment, user requirements, and the need for financial innovation.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements

Topics should demonstrate a degree of innovation, capable of expanding existing theories or proposing new practical application methods, such as proposing new financial strategies or optimizing existing ones, introducing interdisciplinary approaches, or exploring emerging markets or new financial instruments. Topics should stem from practical needs in economics and finance and possess practical or applied value. Strategy design should reflect the entire process of strategy conception and development.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements

Strategy research must balance academic rigor with practical guidance, ensuring that the study possesses both theoretical depth and practical application value. The research question or core objective must be clearly defined. Using economic and financial knowledge, specialized theories, and methods, the study should analyze and elaborate on the conceptualization and design of the strategy, the R&D or creation process, and the demonstration and validation of the strategy's practical application outcomes. On this basis, reflection on and innovation in economic and financial practice are encouraged.

3. Thesis structure

The thesis should demonstrate a substantial workload and conform to academic writing standards. The main body of the thesis generally includes the following sections:

(1) Basic principles and design philosophy of the strategy.

Introduce the strategy's core features and functions. The design philosophy should highlight the strategy's innovative aspects through a comprehensive analysis of risks and returns. The research questions should be clearly defined, objectives should be well-defined, methods should be feasible, and the entire study should be logically coherent.

(2) Specific research plan for the strategy.

A detailed explanation and introduction of the research methods and design. The methods employed must be thoroughly validated and explained. Special attention must be given to the strategy's compliance, ensuring it does not raise social or ethical issues and does not harm the public interest.



(3) Evaluation of strategy effectiveness and robustness.

Conduct multi-dimensional testing of the model and strategy's operational results to ensure the robustness of research conclusions; interpretations of strategy results should be rigorous, avoiding exaggeration of the impact of research findings; provide actionable practical recommendations for market participants such as financial institutions, regulatory bodies, or investors.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

Strategy research should present new perspectives and models, employ novel research methods or technologies, and address challenges that traditional strategies struggle to overcome. Strategy research should provide practical recommendations to relevant decision-makers, thereby advancing the practical application of the field.

2.1.4 Research Report

A research report is a form of academic paper that involves conducting objective research on a specific macroeconomic phenomenon, economic or financial policy, or a particular industry within the national economy in the context of economic and financial practice. It analyzes and studies all the information and materials gathered through investigation to reveal their essence, identify underlying patterns, and present these findings in written form.

A research report should demonstrate that the author possesses a solid foundation in economic and financial theory and systematic professional knowledge, as well as the ability to undertake professional work. The author is required to employ scientific and standardized research methods to conduct in-depth investigations and systematic analyses of the research subject, propose specific solutions to identified problems, and produce a complete survey report aimed at providing decision-making references or policy recommendations for practical issues in economics and finance.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements

The topic of a research report should originate from the field of economic and financial practice, possess a clear professional context and practical value, and focus on a specific issue with sufficient depth, representativeness, and feasibility.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements

The research report should employ professional knowledge, theories, and methodologies to conduct a systematic and in-depth analysis of the research background. Through investigation, standardized methods and procedures should be adopted to collect, organize, and analyze data, and the research findings should



be presented systematically and rigorously. Scientific analysis should be conducted to derive research conclusions. Specific solutions should then be proposed based on these conclusions, and the refinement and innovation of relevant professional knowledge on this basis are encouraged. Finally, the research materials should be organized, where appropriate, and attached following the main body of the thesis.

3. Thesis structure

The thesis should demonstrate a substantial workload and conform to academic writing standards. The main body of the thesis generally includes the following sections:

(1) Investigation

This should involve in-depth fieldwork to obtain detailed data, accurately reflecting objective facts without relying on subjective assumptions, and understanding the research subjects as they truly are. Research subjects must be carefully selected and possess analytical value (including both theoretical and practical value).

(2) Research

This involves conducting a thorough analysis based on objective facts to provide a comprehensive understanding of the research subjects. Research and analysis constitute the core of the research report, encompassing a series of processes such as planning, implementation, data collection, and organization. The purpose is to provide research findings, strategic recommendations, and conclusions to inform future decision-making. Conclusions and recommendations derived from research and analysis should strive to generalize from specific cases to broader principles, avoiding a narrow, case-by-case approach.

(3) Countermeasures

The formulation of countermeasures is an in-depth, complex, and comprehensive research process. To test the effectiveness of countermeasures, a preliminary assessment may be conducted. Countermeasures (conclusions) involve the synthesis and generalization of the research activities, including summarizing problems identified during the practical process and proposing corresponding solutions.

Requirements for the Main Text: The main text presents the author's primary facts and arguments, including an introduction to the issues addressed by the research, its objectives and significance, relevant background, time, location, personnel, and research methods, as well as a detailed account of the conclusions



drawn from practical activities. In terms of writing, the paper must demonstrate an understanding of financial theory and present new perspectives and innovative ideas. It should integrate theory with practice, supported by empirical materials, data, and statistics, and provide guidance and practical insights for real-world work, offering constructive suggestions and recommendations. The content should feature clear and distinct viewpoints, well-defined priorities, a reasonable structure, clear logic, and fluent, concise language.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

The research report should demonstrate innovation in research methods, research tools or processes, or data analysis methods. The research conclusions should be novel and propose practical policy recommendations that provide guidance for the development of relevant professional practices.

2.1.5 Thematic Research

Thematic research theses primarily focus on financial practice and applied research, demonstrating that the degree candidate possesses a solid and comprehensive grasp of foundational theories and systematic, in-depth specialized knowledge in the field of finance, as well as the ability to independently undertake professional practice work.

Thematic research theses fall under the category of applied basic research or applied research theses. Authors are required to address problems with practical application backgrounds, draw upon the field of finance, systematically apply professional knowledge, relevant theories, and analytical tools, and generate outcomes with practical guidance value.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements

The topic of a thematic research thesis should stem from practical financial issues and comply with financial ethical standards. The topic should be closely aligned with the latest developments in finance and emphasize the application of new theoretical methods and analytical tools. The topic should have a clear practical application context, such as a specific analysis of a social or industry issue, while also possessing high research value and innovation. The exploration of new theoretical frameworks or the application of new methods to solve traditional problems is encouraged.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements

A thematic research thesis must accurately define the logical framework of the research problem and focus on demonstrating the scientific validity and



innovativeness of the theories, methodologies, and techniques employed. Through theoretical research and/or empirical analysis, the study should derive conclusions with theoretical value and/or practical significance.

3. Thesis structure

The thesis should possess a complete structure, substantial research content, and conformity with academic writing standards. The main body of the thesis generally includes the following sections:

(1) Introduction

This section should include the research topic, research background, theoretical significance, literature review, research framework, research methodology, theoretical innovations, and thesis structure.

(2) Research Hypotheses and Research Methodology

A preliminary theoretical framework or a series of research hypotheses should be proposed for the research problem. Research methods and research models should be selected according to the research question, and the rationality of the methods and models should be demonstrated.

(3) Research Analysis

This section should provide a detailed explanation of data sources (if applicable) and employ standardized econometric methods or other scientific research approaches to conduct rigorous empirical analyses or theoretical examinations.

(4) Representative Case Analysis (Optional)

Representative cases should be selected from the data sample to illustrate how the conclusions derived from the research analysis and their underlying mechanisms are manifested in actual cases.

(5) Research Conclusions

This section should summarize the major work undertaken and the conclusions reached, discuss the innovative contributions of the thesis and the practical application value of the research outcomes obtained, and provide prospects for future research or constructive recommendations.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

The research conclusions should possess clear theoretical contributions and practical value. The research outcomes should contribute to the advancement of



relevant theories, demonstrate a certain degree of theoretical innovation, and effectively apply theory to practice, thereby showcasing their practical significance.

2.1.6 Empirical Research

Empirical research should quantitatively or qualitatively answer a clearly defined and answerable empirical question, through a test of hypothesis or theory. One of the trends of modern finance is the adoption of computing technologies and tools to provide feasible trading models and strategies for investors with different risk appetites and yield requirements through quantitative analysis of massive financial data and information. An example is providing feasible trading models and strategies for investors with different risk preferences and income demands.

Professionals with quantitative analysis ability are highly demanded in the financial sector, which is in line with the training goal of MF programs to produce high-end and practical financial professionals.

1. Thesis Topic Requirements

The topic needs to be related to financial issues, such as financial management decisions of listed companies or financial institutions, international or macro financial issues, asset pricing issues, etc.

2. Content and Methodological Requirements

With trading models and strategies as an example, the research shall cover the design, development, evaluation, and computerization of models and strategies, which shall be based on tradable financial products, including basic financial products such as stocks, bonds and funds, and innovative financial derivatives. Some examples include trend-based investment strategies, stock index futures arbitrage models, tiered fund investment strategies, paired trading strategies, and algorithmic trading.

Combine the fundamental theories of finance and economics and focus on quantitative research methodology and computer-based tools such as statistical analysis, mathematical finance, computational finance, and data mining.

3. Thesis structure

(1) Introduction

An empirical question shall be put forward in this section that briefly states the proposed research methods and expected results, and puts forward the academic contributions made by the paper.



(2) Theoretical framework, literature review and hypothesis development

Propose the research point, and the innovative and contributive points of this thesis with full discussion and summary of the relevant literatures across the world. More than 20 literatures should be cited, and the cited literatures should not be too old.

(3) Data description and research design

Describe the process of data acquisition and processing, model design, and variable definition.

(4) Empirical analysis

Empirical analysis generally consists of four parts. 1) data analysis and description, including correlation analysis and statistical summary; 2) model verification with data to verify hypothesis; 3) verification results; 4) the robustness test.

(5) Conclusion

Summarize the research of the thesis as well as the results, and put forward relevant policy recommendations.

4. Innovation and Contribution Requirements

Empirical research should focus on clearly defined research questions and the testing of theoretical hypotheses through quantitative or qualitative analytical approaches. Innovation in Master of Finance empirical research may be achieved through advances in research perspectives, data samples, analytical models, and practical applications. By leveraging technological tools to explore financial data, construct quantitative strategies, and generate practically useful findings, the research should produce conclusions with both academic significance and practical value.



2.2 Evaluation Criteria of Thesis

Evaluation index	Evaluation factors			
	Excellent	Good	Qualified	Unqualified
Topic and Literature Review	The topic is realistic, solves the actual problems, and reflects the characteristics of professional categories The richness, novelty and organization of the literature			
Basic knowledge	Understanding of the broad and systematic basic knowledge Correct and flexible adoption of basic theory and professional knowledge			
Analytical Methodology	Proper research method or design, scientific specification of research procedure and process. Difficulty and workload of research contents. Capability of analyzing, solving and investigating problems			
Theoretical Application	Application value of the paper, including professional or industrial background, and economic or social benefits. The guiding role and relative significance of research results, countermeasures or suggestions			
Writing quality	Reasonable structure, strong logic, accurate expression, standard writing Citation norms, rigorous style of study			
Overall Evaluation	Pass	Revise	Fail	
	If any single sub-item is rated as “Unqualified,” the overall evaluation can only be “Revise” or “Fail”			



Chapter 3: Basic Requirements and Evaluation Criteria for Practical Achievements for Degree Application

3.1 Basic Requirements

Practical achievements submitted for degree application should focus on the actual needs of the financial industry and demonstrate characteristics such as innovation, practicality, applicability, and demonstrability. They should reflect the degree candidate's mastery of solid and comprehensive foundational theories and systematic, in-depth specialized knowledge in the field of finance, as well as the ability to independently undertake professional financial practice. Practical achievements should integrate professional financial knowledge and innovative methodologies to address practical problems in specific financial fields, propose effective solutions, and ultimately generate valuable outcomes that contribute to the advancement of the financial industry and financial technological innovation.

3.1.1 Sources and Forms of Practical Achievements

Practical achievements should originate from genuine needs arising in financial practice. Focusing on existing or potential problems in the field of financial practice, candidates should employ various approaches, such as econometric analysis and numerical simulation, in conjunction with emerging technologies including artificial intelligence, to develop innovative solutions.

3.1.2 Form Requirements

Practical achievements submitted for degree application shall consist of two components: **a demonstrable deliverable** and **an achievement report**. The demonstrable deliverable may take various forms, including but not limited to financial practice problem-solving solutions that have received affirmative endorsements or instructions from provincial- or ministerial-level authorities (or their leaders), product design codes, and other relevant outputs. The achievement report serves as the detailed written presentation of the demonstrable deliverable. It provides a comprehensive description of the development process of the practical achievement and serves as an important demonstration of the degree candidate's ability to independently undertake professional practice.



No strict word count limit is imposed on the demonstrable deliverable component. In principle, the main text of the achievement report shall contain no less than 10,000 words.

The specific forms of practical achievements mainly include, but are not limited to, the following categories:

(1) Financial Practice Problem-Solving Solutions

These refer to innovative solutions proposed for existing or potential problems in the field of financial practice and presented in the form of practical achievements. The practical problems addressed should originate from actual needs in the field of economics and finance. The practicality, feasibility, and quality of the proposed solutions are currently evaluated primarily on the basis of affirmative endorsements or instructions received from provincial- or ministerial-level authorities (or their leaders). The solution design should demonstrate the author's mastery of solid foundational theories in economics and finance, systematic specialized knowledge, and the ability to undertake professional work. **The solution (achievement) report** should provide a detailed description of the process through which the solution was developed and the key points of its implementation. It should reflect the entire process of conceptualization, design, and development, and generally include the following components: problem description, problem analysis, solution design, justification and validation of the proposed solution, and implementation pathways.

(2) Financial Product Design

Financial product design refers to the transformation of financial needs and the designer's intentions into a specific financial product or instrument. It may involve the creation of an entirely new product or the improvement and enhancement of an existing product to increase its quality or value, and is presented in the form of a practical achievement. Product design should originate from practical needs in the field of economics and finance and should demonstrate feasibility, practical value, and market competitiveness. **The product design (achievement) report** should provide a detailed description of the product development process and key implementation aspects. It should reflect the entire process of conceptualization, design, development or creation, as well as achievement presentation and validation. The report should include, but is not limited to, the following components: the fundamental concepts and design philosophy of the product, design schemes, product advantages, and product promotion strategies.



3.1.3 Standardization Requirements

1. Declaration of Originality (or Innovation)

The practical achievement submitted for degree application shall include a declaration explicitly stating that the achievement was independently completed and obtained by the degree candidate under the joint supervision of the academic advisor and the practice mentor. The achievement should be scientifically rigorous and compliant with relevant professional standards. Where the achievement involves teamwork, the report shall clearly indicate that it is a team achievement and specify the portions independently completed by the candidate. The practical achievement shall comply with all relevant confidentiality requirements. Ownership of intellectual property rights shall be clearly defined, and no intellectual property disputes shall exist.

2. Writing Standards

The physical components of the practical work, if applicable, should be developed in accordance with the specific requirements of financial practice; no specific requirements are provided here.

The practical achievement report must adhere to basic writing standards, requiring rigorous logic, a reasonable structure, clear organization, fluent expression, standardized charts and tables, and reliable data. The main body of the practical achievement report generally includes the following content:

(1) Overview

This section includes the background and significance of the practical achievement, a review of the current status and development trends of relevant technologies both domestically and internationally, an analysis of related demands, and technical performance requirements.

(2) Solution Design and Feasibility Analysis

This section includes the identification of the problem, the design of the solution, and the analysis of feasibility.

(3) Implementation Plan and Analysis of Test Results

This section includes validation plans, data collection processes, and analyses of test results.

(4) Application Benefits and Impact



This section discusses the application status of the practical achievement, analyzes its economic and social benefits, and evaluates its influence and recognition within the relevant industry.

(5) References

This section lists the principal references cited in the report.

(6) Appendices

This section includes supporting technical materials such as specific implementation plans for solving practical problems, expert evaluation reports, and technical performance testing results. It should also include supporting documentation for practical achievements obtained during the degree program, including but not limited to achievement evaluation or review opinions, invention patents, software, hardware, products, industry standards, software copyrights, achievement awards, evidence of promotion and application, and documentation of economic benefits.

3.1.4 Innovation and Contribution Requirements

Practical achievements submitted for degree application should demonstrate innovation and contribute positively to the development and technological upgrading of the financial industry. Such achievements should generate new methods, new technologies, new solutions, new designs, new standards, or other innovative outcomes in practice, thereby making significant contributions to the advancement of financial practice.

Specifically, such contributions include, but are not limited to, the following:

- Adopting new technologies and proposing new methods to address key technical challenges in relevant financial fields and achieve financial technological innovation;
- Proposing design solutions for new products or upgrading and improving existing products, achieving outstanding implementation outcomes and possessing value for broader promotion and application;
- Providing investigative data and decision-making recommendations for major policy formulation and implementation, and offering innovative insights into problems encountered during financial development;
- Other innovative achievements that successfully address significant practical financial problems and generate substantial outcomes.



3.2 Evaluation Reference Factors

Primary Indicators	Second-Level Indicators	Evaluation Elements
Source of Practical Achievements	Practical Significance of the Source of Practical Achievements	The practical achievements stem from real-world issues in the financial sector, serve major national and societal needs, or address actual financial challenges, and possess practical value and guidance for real-world applications.
Technical Approach and Implementation Plan	Reasonableness of the Technical Approach	The technical approach is scientifically sound and reasonable, with appropriate testing and validation methods and standardized application procedures. The analytical data and supporting evidence are comprehensive.
	Feasibility of the Implementation Plan	The project clearly outlines problem-solving approaches and/or proposed solutions; the proposed solutions demonstrate a degree of specificity and feasibility.
Innovation and Social Benefits	Innovation of Practical Achievements	The work features innovative methods, perspectives, or problem-solving approaches, making unique contributions at the theoretical, methodological, or applied levels, and improving or optimizing existing technologies.
	Economic and Social Benefits of Practical Achievements	The practical achievements have demonstrated significant effectiveness in real-world applications, generating both economic and social benefits and driving the development of the financial industry.
	Prospects for the Dissemination of Practical Achievements	The practical achievements are highly applicable within the industry and possess significant potential for widespread adoption, capable of providing decision-making support or technical services to relevant industries and fields.
Intellectual Property and	Intellectual Property of the	The practical achievements comply with relevant confidentiality regulations, as well as applicable laws,



Academic Standards	Practical Achievements	regulations, and policy requirements, and the ownership of intellectual property is clearly defined. For outcomes resulting from team work, the report must specify that they are team achievements and clearly identify the content completed independently by individuals.
	Standardization of Practical achievements and Summary Reports	The presentation of the practical achievements is fluent and easy to understand; the summary report on the practical achievements complies with basic writing standards, requiring rigorous logic, reasonable structure, clear hierarchy, fluent expression, standardized charts and graphs, and reliable data.



Chapter 4: Critical Thesis/Practical Achievement Assessment

Stages

4.1 Topic Selection and Advisor Assigning

After the thesis/practical achievement process is initiated, students are required to submit a preliminary writing plan to the MF Program within the prescribed period. The plan should include information such as a tentative research topic, a possible area of study, language of writing, and desired advisor. Based on the information provided in the writing plan, the Faculty Director of the MF Program will conduct advisor matching. After the advisor is assigned, the student will be able to find the advisor's information in the ES system (<http://newes.saif.sjtu.edu.cn>). He/she should promptly contact the advisor to discuss the topic of study in further details.

4.2 Thesis/Practical Achievement Proposal

The student is required to complete the Proposal Registration Form under the guidance of the advisor, and submit the form in ES within the specified time. A commitment letter is also to be signed by the student to ensure independent work in completing the thesis/practical achievement. To complete the form, a crucial step prior to the proposal defense, the student must conduct sufficient research on the selected area and clearly articulate the significance of the research and the proposed methods. At this stage, the advisor must review the student's selected topic from a professional perspective, and guide the student towards a proper research direction to ensure the research is feasible. Should the student fail to obtain approval on the Proposal Registration Form, he/she will not be allowed to continue with the following steps. In such case, the student will be required to re-start the thesis/practical achievement in the following round.

4.3 Thesis/Practical Achievement Proposal Defense

Again students must obtain advisors' approval on their selected topic and thesis/practical achievement proposal before completing the proposal defense.

The proposal defense gives students the opportunity to showcase their knowledge about the selected topic. During the defense, students are required to present their proposal and answers questions posed by the defense committee of two



faculty members. The committee will grade the proposal after listening to the defense. A student's proposal can be graded as: pass or fail.

Students who receive pass results can move on to the next step to begin work on the first draft.

Students who receive fail results must, under the advisors' supervision, revise the proposal based on comments received during the proposal defense, and re-submit the Proposal Registration Form with signed approval from the advisor within the specified time. A re-defense shall be arranged two weeks after the proposal defense.

Students who fail to submit the approved proposal registration form or fail in the re-defense will receive a Failure at proposal defense, and will need to re-start the thesis/practical achievement in the following round.

4.4 First Draft

Students must complete at least 80% of the thesis/practical achievement and submit it in ES at the specified time. No external evaluation is needed at this step. The advisor should review and evaluate the student's first draft and give feedback in ES. Students who miss the deadline or receive unsatisfactory results for their first draft will receive a Failure in this step, and will need to re-submit the first draft in the following round.

4.5 Final Draft

Students must fully complete the thesis/practical achievement in this step. The final draft should contain the full structure and content specified in Chapter 2 and 3, as well as meet the paper format and writing standards. Students shall conduct a self-assessment item by item in accordance with the thesis/practical achievement checklist before submission. Students are required to submit the final draft at the specified time and obtain approval from their advisors. Students who miss the deadline or receive unsatisfactory results for their final draft will receive a Failure in this stage, and will need to re-submit the final draft in the following round.

4.6 Originality Check

The MF program team will conduct an Originality Check in the designated system after receiving approved final drafts.

1. Theses/practical achievement reports with a similarity rate **no greater than 15%** are considered as passing and will be submitted for further evaluation.



2. Students with a thesis/practical achievement report receiving a similarity rate **between 15% and 25% (exclusive)** may have a one-time chance to revise the thesis/practical achievement report and re-submit the paper with the consent of the advisor within the specified time. The thesis/practical achievement report will then go through a second originality check. Only if the similarity rate is less or equal to 15% will the student be allowed to continue to the next step. If the similarity rate still goes beyond 15%, the student will no longer be able to continue, and will have to re-submit the revised final draft in the following round.
3. Theses/practical achievement reports with a similarity rate **greater than 25% (inclusive)** will be forwarded to the Thesis Supervision Committee (TSC) for further evaluation to determine whether academic misconduct is suspected:
 - 1) If the conclusion is improper citations, the student must revise the thesis/practical achievement report and re-submit the final draft in the following round.
 - 2) If the conclusion is suspected of core content plagiarism or academic integrity violation, MF Program team will report the case to SAIF Student Affairs Department for further action according to the "Student Academic Integrity Code."

For theses/practical achievement reports requiring a second originality check, the student must provide a written explanation including:

- 1) The source(s) of the "copied literature";
- 2) Identification of the overlapping text within the thesis/practical achievement report (e.g., Introduction, Literature Review sections, etc.), and whether the overlap involves core contributions or main results of the thesis/practical achievement report.

After submitting the written explanation, the student must revise the non-core content as indicated by the originality check report. The revised thesis/practical achievement report must be reviewed and approved by the advisor. Only with the advisor's approval can the second originality check be conducted. Students shall bear the risk of delayed graduation due to revisions or possible academic integrity concerns.



4.7 Random Review by SAIF TSC

The Thesis Supervision Committee (TSC) is in charge of SAIF thesis/practical achievement procedures and quality supervision. After submitting the final draft, a selection of theses/practical achievements will be randomly reviewed by TSC. The list of selected theses/practical achievements and the results will be released in ES.

In this step, theses can be graded as: Pass, Revise and Fail.

Students who receive Pass in the TSC Review can move on to the next step: SJTU Double Blind Review.

A student is required to revise their paper within 10 days of receipt of a Revise result in the TSC Review. The revised paper will be reviewed again by TSC. If it receives a pass, the student can move on to SJTU Double Blind Review. If not, the student will have to re-submit the final draft in the following round, AND the paper will be mandatorily reviewed by TSC.

If a student receives a Fail in the TSC Review, the process will end for that student. He/she will have to re-submit the final draft in the following round, AND the paper will be mandatorily reviewed by TSC.

If a degree applicant disagrees with the academic evaluation conclusions made by relevant academic organizations or personnel during the expert review process of a thesis or practical achievement, the applicant may submit a written request for academic reconsideration to the MF Program and TSC within ten days from the date on which the review result notification is received.

4.8 Internal Review

Theses/practical achievements that are not reviewed by TSC will be evaluated by 2 non-advisor faculty members who will provide feedback on the paper according to the evaluation criteria.

The student's final draft can be graded as Pass, Revise and Fail.

A student is required to revise their paper within 10 days of receipt of a Revise result in the Internal Review. The revised paper will be reviewed again by the original reviewer. If it receives a pass, the student can move on to SJTU Double Blind Review. If not, the student will have to re-submit the final draft in the following round.

If a student receives a Fail in the Internal Review, the process will end for that student. He/she will have to re-submit the final draft in the following round.



If a degree applicant disagrees with the academic evaluation conclusions made by relevant academic organizations or personnel during the expert review process of a thesis or practical achievement, the applicant may submit a written request for academic reconsideration to the MF Program and TSC within ten days from the date on which the review result notification is received.

4.9 SJTU Double Blind Review

In this step SJTU will randomly review a selection of papers in a double-blind manner. Prior to this, the papers will have already passed the originality check and the SAIF/TSC review, and then been uploaded to the Graduate School (GS) system blindly.

Each paper selected will be reviewed by 3 experts. If 2 or more of the 3 experts grade the paper as “unqualified”, the paper will be considered “problematic”. If 1 of the 3 experts grades the paper as “unqualified”, SAIF TSC shall do another round of review and decide whether the paper is "problematic".

Students do not have to wait until their papers pass the SJTU random inspection in order to apply for the final defense. However, if a paper does not pass or requires revision, the student’s application for the degree will be temporarily suspended until the paper is revised as required and approved by both the advisor and the school. If the student has already been awarded a degree, the paper must be revised within a specified time and re-uploaded for archive after being approved by the advisor and the school. If the student fails to revise the paper within the specified time, his/her application for degree will be considered invalid, and the issued degree certificate will be revoked.

4.10 Final Defense

Students who have passed the step 4.5 ~ 4.9 (or are waiting for the results of SJTU Review) should revise their papers again based on the feedback from the previous rounds of review, and produce the final version of their papers under the supervision of the advisors. Then with consent of their advisors and the school, students should apply for Final Defense within a specified time and attend the defense as scheduled.

The Final Defense Committee usually consists of an odd number of faculty members, with no fewer than three members including the chair. To ensure standards, quality and fairness, the defense should adhere to the following agenda (for confidential theses, the defense shall be carried out separately as classified meeting):

- 1) The degree candidate presents the main content of the thesis or practical



work;

- 2) The degree candidate presents the research work and review comments regarding the thesis or practical achievement;
- 3) Committee members pose questions, and the degree candidate responds;
- 4) The defense committee reaches a resolution on whether the degree candidate has passed the defense and announces the decision on the spot.

The outcome of the defense is determined by a vote of the Defense Committee and must be approved by a two-thirds majority of all members. If the defense is passed, a recommendation to confer the master's degree is submitted to the School's Degree Evaluation Committee for review. If the defense is not passed, the candidate may, with the consent of the Defense Committee, reapply and retake the defense within the maximum period of study specified by the university (including the period for converting from certificate completion to graduation).

If a degree candidate objects to the academic evaluation conclusions made by relevant academic organizations or personnel during the defense of the thesis or practical achievement, or during the assessment of the work, the candidate may apply for an academic review to the MF Program and TSC within ten days of receiving the notification. The MF Program and TSC are responsible for handling appeals and reviews regarding the thesis or practical work of master's degree candidates.



Chapter 5: Agenda

Students who plan to graduate in June 2027 should strictly follow the below agenda in order to complete thesis/practical achievement writing. Failure to follow the deadlines of each phase will result in extension of graduation.

Procedures	Due Time
Topic selection	June 28, 2026
Advisor assigning & topic confirmation	June 29- July 26, 2026
Proposal to advisor	September 13, 2026
Proposal approved by advisor	September 20, 2026
Proposal defense	October 12 - 18, 2026
First draft submission	January 3, 2027
First draft approved by advisor	January 17, 2027
Final draft to advisor	February 23, 2027
Final draft approved by advisor	March 7, 2027
TSC review	March 8 - April 7, 2027
Internal review	March 8 - April 7, 2027
Originality check	April 8 - 9, 2027
SJTU double blind review	Mid April, 2027
Final defense	May 10 - 16, 2027
Archive	May 29, 2027